



The World on a Plate

Fifty recipes from kitchens around the globe —
grouped by course, each with its story, its steps,
and something worth knowing before you cook.

50 recipes

8 categories

A cook's field notes

01 Appetizers & Small Plates

Little things to open a meal — bright, sharable, and quick to bring to the table.

Bruschetta al Pomodoro

Italy • Central Italy

Grilled bread rubbed with garlic and piled with ripe tomatoes, basil and olive oil — the purest expression of a summer harvest.

INGREDIENTS

- 8 slices country bread
- 4 ripe tomatoes
- 2 garlic cloves
- 1 handful fresh basil
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- ½ tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Dice ripe tomatoes, toss with salt and drain 10 minutes.
2. Grill thick slices of country bread until charred at the edges.
3. Rub each slice with a cut garlic clove.
4. Fold torn basil and olive oil into the tomatoes, then spoon on top.

GOOD TO KNOW

The name comes from *bruscare*, Roman dialect for "to roast over coals." Peasants used it to test the year's fresh-pressed olive oil.

Hummus bi Tahini

Levant · Eastern Mediterranean

A silken purée of chickpeas and sesame tahini, sharpened with lemon and garlic and pooled with green olive oil.

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g dried chickpeas
- 120 g tahini
- 2 lemons
- 2 garlic cloves
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 4 tbsp olive oil
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Simmer soaked chickpeas with a pinch of baking soda until very soft.
2. Blend hot chickpeas with tahini, lemon juice, garlic and ice water.
3. Whip until pale and fluffy, seasoning with salt and cumin.
4. Swirl into a bowl and top with oil, paprika and whole chickpeas.

GOOD TO KNOW

Ownership of hummus is fiercely debated across the region; Lebanon once tried to trademark it. The baking soda trick is what makes it restaurant-smooth.

Guacamole

Mexico · Aztec origins

Hand-mashed avocado brightened with lime, chilli, onion and coriander — coarse, fresh, and made to order.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 ripe avocados
- ½ white onion
- 1 serrano chilli
- 2 tbsp chopped coriander
- 1 lime
- ½ tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Mash ripe avocados in a bowl, leaving some chunks.
2. Stir in finely diced white onion, serrano chilli and coriander.
3. Season with lime juice and salt to taste.
4. Press plastic wrap onto the surface until serving to keep it green.

GOOD TO KNOW

The word comes from the Nahuatl *āhuacamolli* — "avocado sauce." The Aztecs were making it before the Spanish arrived in the 1500s.

Gỏi Cuốn (Fresh Spring Rolls)

Vietnam · Southern Vietnam

Translucent rice-paper rolls packed with prawn, herbs, vermicelli and lettuce, served cool with a peanut dipping sauce.

INGREDIENTS

- 12 rice-paper wrappers
- 12 cooked prawns
- 100 g rice vermicelli
- 4 lettuce leaves
- 1 handful mint & coriander
- 3 tbsp hoisin sauce
- 2 tbsp peanut butter

PREPARATION

1. Soften a rice-paper sheet in warm water for a few seconds.
2. Layer lettuce, noodles, herbs and halved cooked prawns near one edge.
3. Fold in the sides and roll tightly like a burrito.
4. Serve with hoisin-peanut sauce.

GOOD TO KNOW

Unlike Chinese spring rolls these are never fried — the appeal is the cool, raw crunch. The prawns are placed pink-side down so they show through the wrapper.

Patatas Bravas

Spain · Madrid

Crisp fried potato cubes under a smoky, faintly spicy tomato sauce — the tapas bar's most argued-over plate.

INGREDIENTS

- 800 g potatoes
- 500 ml oil, for frying
- 400 g tomato
- 1 tbsp smoked paprika
- ¼ tsp cayenne
- 2 garlic cloves
- 4 tbsp aioli (optional)

PREPARATION

1. Parboil potato cubes, then dry thoroughly.
2. Fry twice until deeply golden and crisp.
3. Simmer tomato, smoked paprika and a little cayenne into a sauce.
4. Spoon sauce over the hot potatoes; add aioli if you like.

GOOD TO KNOW

Bravas means "fierce" — a nod to the heat. In Madrid the sauce is paprika-red and creamy; in Barcelona it's often two sauces at once.

Tzatziki

Greece · Aegean

Thick strained yoghurt with grated cucumber, garlic and dill — cooling, tart, and endlessly useful.

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g Greek yoghurt
- 1 cucumber
- 2 garlic cloves
- 2 tbsp dill
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- ½ tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Grate cucumber, salt it and squeeze out the water.
2. Stir into thick Greek yoghurt with crushed garlic.
3. Add olive oil, lemon and chopped dill.
4. Chill an hour so the flavours settle.

GOOD TO KNOW

Squeezing the cucumber is non-negotiable — skip it and the dip turns watery within the hour. The name traces to a Turkish word, *cacık*.

Edamame with Sea Salt

Japan

Young soybeans boiled in their pods and showered with flaky salt — the simplest thing to nibble with a cold drink.

INGREDIENTS

- 300 g edamame pods
- 1 litre water
- 1 tbsp flaky sea salt

PREPARATION

1. Boil salted water in a wide pot.
2. Add pods and cook 4–5 minutes until bright and tender.
3. Drain well and toss with coarse sea salt.
4. Serve warm; squeeze the beans straight from the pod.

GOOD TO KNOW

Eda-mame literally means "branch bean," from the old practice of selling them still on the stem. They're a complete protein.

02 Soups & Salads

Bowls that warm and salads that refresh — the honest middle of the meal.

Tom Yum Goong

Thailand · Central Thailand

A hot-and-sour prawn soup ringing with lemongrass, galangal, lime leaf and chilli.

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g prawns
- 2 lemongrass stalks
- 4 slices galangal
- 4 kaffir lime leaves
- 150 g mushrooms
- 2 tbsp fish sauce
- 2 limes
- 1 tbsp chilli paste
- 2 tbsp coriander

PREPARATION

1. Simmer stock with bruised lemongrass, galangal and torn lime leaves.
2. Add mushrooms and prawns; cook until the prawns curl.
3. Season off the heat with fish sauce, lime juice and chilli paste.
4. Finish with fresh coriander.

GOOD TO KNOW

Tom means boil, *yum* means a sour-spicy mix. The lime juice always goes in last — boiling it turns the sourness bitter.

French Onion Soup

France · Paris

Slow-caramelised onions in beef broth under a raft of toasted bread and bubbling Gruyère.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 large onions
- 50 g butter
- 150 ml white wine
- 1.2 l beef stock
- 3 thyme sprigs
- ½ baguette
- 150 g Gruyère

PREPARATION

1. Cook sliced onions low and slow until deep mahogany, 45+ minutes.
2. Deglaze with white wine, then add beef stock and thyme.
3. Ladle into oven bowls, float toasted baguette on top.
4. Blanket with grated Gruyère and grill until molten.

GOOD TO KNOW

Once "poor man's food," it became a Parisian late-night ritual at the old Les Halles market. Patience with the onions is the whole recipe.

Gazpacho Andaluz

Spain · Andalusia

A chilled raw-vegetable soup of tomato, cucumber, pepper and bread, blitzed with sherry vinegar and oil.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 kg ripe tomatoes
- 1 cucumber
- 1 green pepper
- 1 garlic clove
- 50 g stale bread
- 4 tbsp olive oil
- 2 tbsp sherry vinegar
- 1 tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Blend ripe tomatoes, cucumber, pepper, garlic and stale bread.
2. Emulsify with olive oil, sherry vinegar and salt.
3. Strain for a silky texture if you like.
4. Chill thoroughly and serve very cold.

GOOD TO KNOW

It predates the tomato — early Andalusian versions were just bread, oil, garlic and water, a farmworker's way to survive the heat.

Minestrone

Italy · Northern Italy

A thick, seasonal vegetable and bean soup bound with a little pasta — different in every kitchen.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 onion
- 2 carrots
- 2 celery stalks
- 300 g seasonal vegetables
- 400 g cannellini beans
- 400 g tomato
- 1.5 l stock
- 100 g small pasta
- 40 g Parmesan

PREPARATION

1. Sweat a soffritto of onion, carrot and celery in olive oil.
2. Add seasonal vegetables, beans, tomato and stock.
3. Simmer until everything is tender.
4. Add small pasta near the end; finish with Parmesan.

GOOD TO KNOW

The name simply means "big soup." There's no fixed recipe — it was built from whatever the garden and larder offered that week.

Greek Village Salad (Horiatiki)

Greece

Chunky tomato, cucumber, pepper and onion with olives and a slab of feta — no lettuce in sight.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 tomatoes
- 1 cucumber
- 1 green pepper
- ½ red onion
- 80 g Kalamata olives
- 200 g feta
- 1 tsp dried oregano
- 4 tbsp olive oil

PREPARATION

1. Cut tomatoes and cucumber into big rustic chunks.
2. Add sliced onion, green pepper and Kalamata olives.
3. Top with a whole slab of feta, not crumbled.
4. Dress only with olive oil, oregano and salt.

GOOD TO KNOW

Real *horiatiki* never contains lettuce — that's a tourist addition. The feta goes on as one piece so each person breaks their own.

Tabbouleh

Lebanon

A herb salad far more than a grain one — mountains of parsley and mint with just a little bulgur.

INGREDIENTS

- 50 g fine bulgur
- 3 bunches flat-leaf parsley
- 1 bunch mint
- 2 tomatoes
- 3 spring onions
- 2 lemons
- 4 tbsp olive oil
- ½ tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Soak fine bulgur briefly until just tender.
2. Finely chop huge amounts of flat-leaf parsley and mint.
3. Add diced tomato and spring onion.
4. Dress with lemon juice, olive oil and salt.

GOOD TO KNOW

In Lebanon it is emphatically a parsley salad; the bulgur is a seasoning. Western versions that flip the ratio would look strange in Beirut.

Miso Soup

Japan

A daily bowl of dashi seasoned with fermented soybean paste, tofu and wakame.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 strip kombu
- 10 g bonito flakes
- 3 tbsp miso paste
- 150 g tofu
- 2 tbsp wakame
- 2 spring onions

PREPARATION

1. Make dashi from kombu and bonito flakes.
2. Add cubed tofu and rehydrated wakame; warm through.
3. Whisk miso paste into a little broth, then stir back in.
4. Never boil after adding miso; garnish with spring onion.

GOOD TO KNOW

Boiling kills the living cultures and dulls the aroma, so miso always goes in off the boil. Many Japanese households eat it at breakfast.

03 Main Courses

The centrepieces — braises, roasts and stews worth the time they take.

Chicken Tikka Masala

United Kingdom / India

Char-grilled marinated chicken in a creamy, spiced tomato gravy — comfort food of two nations.

INGREDIENTS

- 800 g chicken
- 150 g yoghurt
- 2 tbsp garam masala
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- 3 garlic cloves
- 400 g tomato
- 150 ml cream
- 30 g butter
- 2 tbsp coriander

PREPARATION

1. Marinate chicken in yoghurt, garam masala, ginger and garlic.
2. Grill or broil until charred at the edges.
3. Simmer a sauce of tomato, cream, butter and spices.
4. Fold the chicken in and finish with cream and coriander.

GOOD TO KNOW

Legend credits a Glasgow chef who improvised a sauce for a diner who found his curry too dry. It's often called Britain's true national dish.

Beef Bourguignon

France · Burgundy

Beef braised slowly in red wine with mushrooms, pearl onions and bacon until spoon-tender.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 kg beef chuck
- 150 g bacon
- 500 ml red Burgundy
- 500 ml beef stock
- 250 g mushrooms
- 200 g pearl onions
- 3 garlic cloves
- 1 bouquet garni
- 2 tbsp flour

PREPARATION

1. Brown floured beef chunks in bacon fat.
2. Deglaze with red Burgundy and add stock, garlic and herbs.
3. Braise low for 2–3 hours until fork-tender.
4. Add sautéed mushrooms and glazed pearl onions to finish.

GOOD TO KNOW

Once a peasant way to tenderise tough cuts, it was elevated to haute cuisine by Escoffier and later by Julia Child for American cooks.

Spaghetti alla Carbonara

Italy · Rome

Pasta bound in a glossy sauce of egg, Pecorino and guanciale — no cream, ever.

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g spaghetti
- 150 g guanciale
- 3 eggs + 1 yolk
- 70 g Pecorino Romano
- 1 tsp black pepper

PREPARATION

1. Crisp diced guanciale in its own fat.
2. Whisk eggs with grated Pecorino and lots of black pepper.
3. Toss hot drained pasta with the pork, off the heat.
4. Add the egg mix with pasta water, tossing to a cream.

GOOD TO KNOW

The "cream" is only egg and cheese emulsified with starchy water. Roman cooks insist the pan comes off the heat or you get scrambled eggs.

Goulash (Gulyás)

Hungary

A paprika-rich beef and onion stew, somewhere between a soup and a braise.

INGREDIENTS

- 800 g beef
- 3 onions
- 2 tbsp lard
- 3 tbsp sweet paprika
- 1 tsp caraway
- 2 potatoes
- 1 green pepper

PREPARATION

1. Soften a generous amount of onion in lard.
2. Stir in sweet paprika off the heat so it doesn't scorch.
3. Add beef, caraway and water; simmer gently for hours.
4. Add potato and pepper toward the end.

GOOD TO KNOW

The name means "herdsman's" — it was cooked by cattle drovers on the plains. Paprika only reached Hungary via the Ottomans in the 16th century.

Chicken Tagine with Olives & Lemon

Morocco

Chicken slow-cooked in a conical clay pot with preserved lemon, green olives and warm spice.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 whole chicken
- 2 onions
- 1 preserved lemon
- 100 g green olives
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- 1 pinch saffron
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp turmeric

PREPARATION

1. Rub chicken with ginger, saffron, cumin and turmeric.
2. Brown, then nestle into onions with a little water.
3. Cover and cook low until falling off the bone.
4. Add preserved lemon and olives near the end.

GOOD TO KNOW

The lid's cone shape traps steam and returns it to the pot, so almost no liquid is needed — a design born of scarce fuel and water.

Jerk Chicken

Jamaica

Chicken marinated in fiery scotch bonnet, allspice and thyme, then smoked over pimento wood.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 kg chicken
- 2 scotch bonnets
- 1 tbsp ground allspice
- 4 thyme sprigs
- 3 garlic cloves
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- 2 limes
- 3 spring onions

PREPARATION

1. Blend scotch bonnet, allspice, thyme, garlic, ginger and lime.
2. Marinate the chicken overnight.
3. Grill slowly over low coals, ideally with wood smoke.
4. Baste and turn until charred and cooked through.

GOOD TO KNOW

"Jerk" descends from the cooking of the Maroons — escaped enslaved people who hid in the mountains. Allspice (pimento) is the signature.

Butter Chicken (Murgh Makhani)

India • Delhi

Tandoori chicken finished in a velvety tomato-butter sauce, mild and rich.

INGREDIENTS

- 800 g chicken
- 150 g yoghurt
- 400 g tomato
- 50 g cashews
- 60 g butter
- 150 ml cream
- 2 tbsp garam masala
- 1 tbsp kasuri methi

PREPARATION

1. Grill yoghurt-marinated chicken until lightly charred.
2. Simmer tomato with cashew, butter, cream and spices.
3. Blend the sauce smooth.
4. Add the chicken and finish with a knob of butter.

GOOD TO KNOW

It was invented in the 1950s at Delhi's Moti Mahal to use up unsold tandoori chicken — the tomato-butter gravy kept the meat from drying out.

Wiener Schnitzel

Austria · Vienna

A wafer-thin veal cutlet breaded and fried until the crumb puffs away from the meat.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 veal cutlets
- 100 g flour
- 2 eggs
- 150 g fine breadcrumbs
- 300 g clarified butter or oil
- 1 lemon
- 2 tbsp parsley

PREPARATION

1. Pound veal cutlets very thin.
2. Dredge in flour, egg, then breadcrumbs.
3. Fry in plenty of hot fat, swirling the pan.
4. Serve with lemon and parsley potatoes.

GOOD TO KNOW

By Austrian law "Wiener Schnitzel" must be veal; the pork version must be called *Schnitzel Wiener Art*. Swirling the fat is what makes the crumb "soufflé."

04 From the Sea

Fish and shellfish from coasts around the world.

Paella Valenciana

Spain · Valencia

Saffron rice cooked flat and wide over fire, prized for the crisp *socarrat* at the bottom.

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g bomba rice
- 500 g chicken or rabbit
- 150 g green beans
- 1 tomato & onion sofrito
- 1 pinch saffron
- 1 l stock
- 4 tbsp olive oil

PREPARATION

1. Sear chicken, rabbit or seafood in the wide pan.
2. Add sofrito, then rice, saffron stock and beans.
3. Spread the rice flat and do not stir once liquid is in.
4. Finish on high heat to crisp the bottom layer.

GOOD TO KNOW

Valencians say the *socarrat* — the caramelised crust — is the best part. Stirring the rice, or adding chorizo, is considered heresy there.

Ceviche

Peru

Raw fish "cooked" in lime juice with onion, chilli and coriander, served with the tangy *leche de tigre*.

INGREDIENTS

- 500 g fresh white fish
- 6 limes
- 1 red onion
- 1 ají or chilli
- 2 tbsp coriander
- 1 sweet potato
- 1 corn cob
- 1 tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Cut very fresh white fish into cubes.
2. Toss with fresh lime juice, salt and sliced chilli.
3. Add red onion and coriander; rest just a few minutes.
4. Serve at once with sweet potato and corn.

GOOD TO KNOW

The citric acid denatures the proteins the way heat would, without cooking. Peru celebrates a national Ceviche Day every 28 June.

Fish and Chips

United Kingdom

Battered white fish deep-fried crisp, with thick-cut chips and a shake of vinegar.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 white fish fillets
- 200 g flour
- 300 ml beer or sparkling water
- 1 kg potatoes
- 1 l oil, for frying
- 1 tsp salt
- malt vinegar, to serve

PREPARATION

1. Make a cold batter of flour and beer or sparkling water.
2. Dip cod or haddock and fry until golden and crisp.
3. Twice-fry chips for a fluffy inside.
4. Season with salt and malt vinegar.

GOOD TO KNOW

The pairing dates to Victorian Britain; it was one of the few foods never rationed in WWII, deemed vital to morale.

Moules Marinières

France / Belgium

Mussels steamed open in white wine, shallots and parsley — eaten with bread or fries.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 kg mussels
- 2 shallots
- 2 garlic cloves
- 40 g butter
- 200 ml white wine
- 3 tbsp parsley

PREPARATION

1. Scrub and debeard fresh mussels, discarding any open ones.
2. Sweat shallots and garlic in butter.
3. Add white wine, then the mussels; cover and steam.
4. Toss with parsley once the shells open.

GOOD TO KNOW

Any mussel that stays shut after cooking should be thrown out. In Belgium the classic partner is a cone of fries, not bread.

Maki Sushi

Japan

Vinegared rice and fillings rolled in nori and sliced into neat rounds.

INGREDIENTS

- 300 g sushi rice
- 3 tbsp rice vinegar
- 4 nori sheets
- 200 g fresh fish
- 1 cucumber or avocado
- 1 tsp wasabi
- soy sauce, to serve

PREPARATION

1. Season warm rice with vinegar, sugar and salt; cool.
2. Spread over nori on a bamboo mat, leaving a border.
3. Lay fish and vegetables in a line and roll tightly.
4. Wet a sharp knife and slice into pieces.

GOOD TO KNOW

Sushi began as a preservation method — fish fermented in rice that was then discarded. The fresh style we know is a 19th-century Tokyo fast food.

Salmon Teriyaki

Japan

Pan-seared salmon glazed in a glossy sweet-savoury sauce of soy, mirin and sake.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 salmon fillets
- 4 tbsp soy sauce
- 3 tbsp mirin
- 2 tbsp sake
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tbsp sesame seeds

PREPARATION

1. Sear salmon fillets skin-side down until crisp.
2. Simmer soy, mirin, sake and sugar into a glaze.
3. Spoon the sauce over and reduce until it clings.
4. Serve with rice and sesame seeds.

GOOD TO KNOW

Teri means "shine" — the gloss is the whole point. The sugar and mirin caramelise into that lacquered finish.

05 Vegetarian & Vegan

Plant-forward plates that stand on their own.

Ratatouille

France · Provence

A Provençal stew of aubergine, courgette, pepper and tomato, each cooked to keep its character.

INGREDIENTS

- 1 aubergine
- 2 courgettes
- 2 bell peppers
- 4 tomatoes
- 1 onion
- 3 garlic cloves
- 1 tbsp herbes de Provence
- 4 tbsp olive oil
- 1 handful basil

PREPARATION

1. Cook aubergine, courgette and pepper separately in oil.
2. Make a garlicky tomato base with herbs.
3. Fold the vegetables in gently.
4. Simmer briefly and finish with basil.

GOOD TO KNOW

Cooking each vegetable apart keeps them from turning to mush — the fine-diced *confit byaldi* layering was popularised by chef Michel Guérard.

Falafel

Middle East · Egypt / Levant

Deep-fried patties of ground chickpeas and herbs, crisp outside and green within.

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g dried chickpeas
- 1 bunch parsley & coriander
- 3 garlic cloves
- 1 onion
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp coriander seed
- 1 l oil, for frying
- 4 pita breads

PREPARATION

1. Blend soaked (not cooked) chickpeas with herbs, garlic and spice.
2. Rest the mix, then shape into balls or patties.
3. Deep-fry until deep brown and crisp.
4. Serve in pita with tahini and salad.

GOOD TO KNOW

The chickpeas must be soaked raw, never cooked — canned ones fall apart in the oil. Egypt's version, *ta'ameya*, uses fava beans instead.

Palak Paneer

India · Punjab

Fresh cheese cubes simmered in a smooth, spiced spinach purée.

INGREDIENTS

- 500 g spinach
- 250 g paneer
- 1 onion
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- 3 garlic cloves
- 1 green chilli
- 3 tbsp cream
- 1 tsp garam masala

PREPARATION

1. Blanch spinach briefly, then blend to a bright purée.
2. Fry onion, ginger, garlic and spices.
3. Add the spinach and a splash of cream.
4. Fold in pan-fried paneer cubes.

GOOD TO KNOW

Blanching and shocking the spinach in ice keeps the sauce vivid green rather than khaki. Paneer doesn't melt, so it holds its shape in the gravy.

Shakshuka

North Africa · Tunisia / Maghreb

Eggs poached in a simmering sauce of tomato, pepper and cumin, eaten straight from the pan.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 eggs
- 400 g tomatoes
- 1 red pepper
- 1 onion
- 2 garlic cloves
- 1 tsp paprika
- 1 tsp cumin
- 3 tbsp olive oil

PREPARATION

1. Soften onion and pepper, then add tomato, paprika and cumin.
2. Simmer into a thick sauce.
3. Make wells and crack in eggs.
4. Cover until the whites set but yolks stay soft.

GOOD TO KNOW

The name means "a mixture" in Maghrebi Arabic. It travelled from Tunisia to become an all-day staple across Israel and the Levant.

Caprese Salad

Italy · Capri

Mozzarella, tomato and basil in the colours of the Italian flag, dressed only with oil.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 ripe tomatoes
- 250 g fresh mozzarella
- 1 handful basil
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- ½ tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Slice ripe tomatoes and fresh mozzarella.
2. Alternate on a plate with whole basil leaves.
3. Drizzle with good olive oil and a little salt.
4. Serve at room temperature.

GOOD TO KNOW

Said to be created on Capri to honour the tricolore flag — red, white and green. Traditionalists never add balsamic vinegar.

Pad Thai (Vegetarian)

Thailand

Stir-fried rice noodles balanced between sweet, sour and salty, with tofu, peanuts and lime.

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g rice noodles
- 200 g firm tofu
- 1 egg
- 2 tbsp tamarind paste
- 2 tbsp palm sugar
- 100 g bean sprouts
- 40 g peanuts
- 1 lime

PREPARATION

1. Soak rice noodles until pliable.
2. Stir-fry tofu, then push aside and scramble egg.
3. Add noodles and a tamarind-palm-sugar sauce.
4. Toss with bean sprouts, peanuts and lime.

GOOD TO KNOW

Pad Thai was promoted in the 1930s–40s as a national dish to boost rice-noodle use and reduce rice consumption during wartime shortages.

Dal Tadka

India

Soft yellow lentils finished with a sizzling *tadka* of ghee, cumin and chilli poured over the top.

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g yellow lentils
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 3 tbsp ghee
- 1 tsp cumin seeds
- 3 garlic cloves
- 2 dried chillies
- 2 tbsp coriander

PREPARATION

1. Simmer lentils with turmeric until soft.
2. In a separate pan heat ghee with cumin, garlic and dried chilli.
3. Pour the sizzling spice oil over the dal.
4. Stir through and finish with coriander.

GOOD TO KNOW

The *tadka* — tempering whole spices in hot fat and adding them last — is a defining technique of Indian cooking, releasing aromas instantly.

06 Breakfast & Brunch

Ways the world begins the day.

Fluffy American Pancakes

United States

Tall, tender buttermilk pancakes stacked high with butter and maple syrup.

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 300 ml buttermilk
- 1 egg
- 30 g butter
- maple syrup, to serve

PREPARATION

1. Whisk dry ingredients with baking powder.
2. Fold in buttermilk, egg and melted butter until just combined.
3. Rest the batter; lumps are fine.
4. Cook on a medium griddle, flipping when bubbles set.

GOOD TO KNOW

Over-mixing develops gluten and makes them rubbery — a lumpy batter is the secret to a fluffy stack. Real maple syrup is graded by colour.

French Toast (Pain Perdu)

France

Stale bread soaked in custard and fried golden — literally "lost bread," rescued from the bin.

INGREDIENTS

- 6 slices day-old bread
- 3 eggs
- 150 ml milk
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla
- 30 g butter

PREPARATION

1. Whisk eggs, milk, sugar and vanilla.
2. Soak thick slices of day-old bread.
3. Fry in butter until golden on both sides.
4. Dust with sugar or drizzle with syrup.

GOOD TO KNOW

The French name means "lost bread" — the dish exists precisely to revive bread too stale to eat plain. Recipes for it date to Roman times.

Congee (Rice Porridge)

China

Rice simmered long in plenty of water into a silky savoury porridge, topped to taste.

INGREDIENTS

- 150 g rice
- 1.5 l water or stock
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- 2 spring onions
- 1 tbsp soy sauce
- toppings to taste

PREPARATION

1. Simmer rice with lots of water or stock, stirring occasionally.
2. Cook an hour or more until broken down and creamy.
3. Season with a little salt or soy.
4. Top with ginger, spring onion, egg or shredded chicken.

GOOD TO KNOW

Eaten across Asia as a gentle food for the sick and elderly, congee stretches a little rice a very long way — a comfort born partly of thrift.

Menemen

Turkey

Eggs scrambled softly into a stew of tomato, green pepper and chilli flakes.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 eggs
- 3 tomatoes
- 2 green peppers
- 1 tsp pul biber
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- ½ tsp salt

PREPARATION

1. Soften green peppers in olive oil.
2. Add chopped tomato and pul biber; cook down.
3. Pour in beaten eggs and stir gently to soft curds.
4. Serve straight from the pan with bread.

GOOD TO KNOW

Turks debate endlessly whether onion belongs in menemen — most purists say no. It's cooked and eaten from the same pan, shared at the table.

Overnight Oats

Switzerland (from Bircher muesli)

Rolled oats softened overnight in milk or yoghurt with fruit — breakfast made while you sleep.

INGREDIENTS

- 80 g rolled oats
- 150 ml milk or yoghurt
- 1 tbsp chia seeds
- 1 apple or handful berries
- 1 tbsp honey
- 2 tbsp nuts

PREPARATION

1. Stir oats with milk or yoghurt and a little sweetener.
2. Add chia, grated apple or berries.
3. Cover and refrigerate overnight.
4. Top with fresh fruit and nuts before eating.

GOOD TO KNOW

The idea descends from *Bircher müesli*, devised around 1900 by Swiss doctor Maximilian Bircher-Benner for hospital patients.

07 Desserts

Sweet endings, from the barely-set to the deep-fried.

Tiramisù

Italy · Veneto

Coffee-soaked savoiardi layered with mascarpone cream and dusted with cocoa.

INGREDIENTS

- 24 savoiardi biscuits
- 4 egg yolks
- 100 g sugar
- 500 g mascarpone
- 300 ml strong espresso
- 2 tbsp cocoa

PREPARATION

1. Whip egg yolks with sugar, then fold in mascarpone.
2. Dip savoiardi biscuits briefly in strong coffee.
3. Layer biscuits and cream in a dish.
4. Chill several hours; dust with cocoa to serve.

GOOD TO KNOW

The name means "pick me up" — a nod to the coffee and, some say, the liqueur. It's a surprisingly modern dish, appearing only in the 1960s–70s.

Crème Brûlée

France

A silky vanilla custard under a brittle, torched sugar crust you crack with a spoon.

INGREDIENTS

- 500 ml double cream
- 1 vanilla pod
- 5 egg yolks
- 100 g caster sugar

PREPARATION

1. Heat cream with vanilla and temper into egg yolks and sugar.
2. Pour into ramekins and bake in a water bath until just set.
3. Chill thoroughly.
4. Sprinkle sugar on top and torch to a hard caramel.

GOOD TO KNOW

France, England and Spain each claim it (as *crema catalana*). The contrast of cold custard and warm glass crust is the whole pleasure.

Baklava

Turkey / Greece · Ottoman

Layers of paper-thin filo and chopped nuts drenched in spiced syrup or honey.

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g filo pastry
- 300 g walnuts or pistachios
- 200 g butter
- 200 g sugar
- 150 g honey
- 1 lemon
- 1 tsp cinnamon

PREPARATION

1. Brush filo sheets with butter, layering with nuts between.
2. Cut into diamonds before baking.
3. Bake until deeply golden and crisp.
4. Pour cool syrup over the hot pastry and let it soak.

GOOD TO KNOW

Perfected in the kitchens of Istanbul's Topkapı Palace. Pouring cool syrup on hot pastry (or vice versa) is what keeps it crisp, not soggy.

Churros

Spain

Ridged sticks of fried dough rolled in sugar, for dunking in thick hot chocolate.

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g flour
- 300 ml water
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 l oil, for frying
- 100 g sugar
- 150 g dark chocolate

PREPARATION

1. Cook a simple flour-and-water dough (a choux-like paste).
2. Pipe through a star nozzle into hot oil.
3. Fry until golden and crisp.
4. Toss in sugar; serve with dipping chocolate.

GOOD TO KNOW

The star-shaped ridges aren't decorative — they increase the surface area so the churro crisps evenly and won't burst in the oil.

Mochi (Daifuku)

Japan

Chewy pounded-rice cakes wrapped around a filling of sweet red bean.

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g glutinous rice flour
- 80 g sugar
- 180 ml water
- 200 g anko (red bean paste)
- 3 tbsp cornflour

PREPARATION

1. Steam or microwave glutinous rice flour with sugar and water.
2. Knead into a stretchy dough, dusting with starch.
3. Flatten pieces and wrap around a ball of anko paste.
4. Pinch closed and dust to serve.

GOOD TO KNOW

Traditional mochi is made by pounding steamed rice with huge wooden mallets — a New Year ritual called *mochitsuki*. Eat carefully; it's very sticky.

New York Cheesecake

United States · New York

A dense, tall baked cheesecake, rich with cream cheese on a buttery crumb base.

INGREDIENTS

- 900 g cream cheese
- 200 g sugar
- 3 eggs
- 120 ml cream
- 200 g digestive biscuits
- 80 g butter
- 1 tsp vanilla

PREPARATION

1. Press a biscuit-crumb base into a springform tin.
2. Beat cream cheese with sugar, eggs and a little cream.
3. Bake in a water bath until just set with a slight wobble.
4. Cool slowly, then chill overnight.

GOOD TO KNOW

The dense style was popularised by Manhattan's Jewish delis in the early 1900s. Slow cooling prevents the cracked top that plagues rushed bakers.

Gulab Jamun

India

Deep-fried milk-solid dumplings soaked warm in rose-and-cardamom syrup.

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g khoya or milk powder
- 50 g flour
- 2 tbsp ghee
- 400 g sugar
- 4 cardamom pods
- 1 tsp rose water
- 1 l oil, for frying

PREPARATION

1. Make a soft dough from milk powder (khoya), flour and ghee.
2. Roll into smooth crack-free balls.
3. Fry gently on low heat until deep brown.
4. Soak in warm cardamom-rose syrup until plump.

GOOD TO KNOW

The name blends Persian words — *gulab* (rose water) and *jamun* (a dark berry it resembles). Frying too hot leaves the centre raw.

08 Drinks

To pour alongside — or to end on.

Masala Chai

India

Black tea simmered with milk, ginger and warm spices — sweet, strong and everywhere.

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tsp black tea
- 400 ml milk
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- 4 cardamom pods
- 2 cloves
- 1 cinnamon stick
- 3 tsp sugar

PREPARATION

1. Crush ginger, cardamom, clove and cinnamon.
2. Simmer with water and black tea leaves.
3. Add milk and sugar and bring back to a boil.
4. Strain and serve steaming hot.

GOOD TO KNOW

Saying "chai tea" is really saying "tea tea" — *chai* already means tea. The spiced-milk style spread with British-era tea marketing in India.

Mango Lassi

India · Punjab

A cooling blend of yoghurt, ripe mango and a whisper of cardamom.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 ripe mangoes
- 250 g yoghurt
- 100 ml milk
- 2 tbsp sugar
- ¼ tsp cardamom
- 1 handful ice

PREPARATION

1. Blend ripe mango pulp with plain yoghurt.
2. Add a little milk or water to loosen.
3. Sweeten to taste and add a pinch of cardamom.
4. Serve chilled over ice.

GOOD TO KNOW

Lassi began as a savoury, salted yoghurt drink; the sweet mango version is the newcomer. It's a natural foil to the heat of a spicy meal.

Moroccan Mint Tea

Morocco

Green tea steeped with fresh spearmint and plenty of sugar, poured from a height into small glasses.

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tbsp gunpowder green tea
- 1 large bunch spearmint
- 4 tbsp sugar
- 750 ml boiling water

PREPARATION

1. Rinse gunpowder green tea, then steep in boiling water.
2. Add a large bunch of fresh mint and sugar.
3. Steep a few minutes.
4. Pour from high above the glass to build a foam.

GOOD TO KNOW

Pouring from a height aerates the tea and crowns each glass with foam — a sign of hospitality. Refusing a glass is considered impolite.